# Corpus: legends of kings → Hebrew (Gen 11 and Exod 2)

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Read `../translation-guidelines.md` first, then this file, then the shared `renderings.md` (binding), then `translator-brief--kings.md`, then the project's `project.md`.

## Goal (Round 2, run 6 of `../curated-translation-candidates.md`, 2026-10-21)

Translate, complete, two legends that the ancient Near East told about its kings and their beginnings:

1. **Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta** (ETCSL 1.8.2.3; Sumerian; composed in the Ur III or early Old Babylonian
period, copied in the OB schools of Nippur and Ur; 641 composite entries). Enmerkar, king of Uruk and "son of Utu",
asks Inana to make the distant highland city of Aratta send gold, silver and lapis lazuli and its craftsmen to build
her temple in Uruk and Enki's Abzu in Eridu. A messenger runs back and forth across seven mountain ranges; the two
kings exchange threats and riddles (the grain carried in nets; a sceptre of no known material; a champion of no
colour); the messenger's mouth grows "heavy", and Enmerkar invents writing on clay; Iškur's storm brings wild wheat
to Aratta; the end (damaged) seems to settle the contest by trade. Inside the first message: **the "spell of
Nudimmud"** (134–155), on a time when all peoples addressed Enlil "in one tongue" until Enki "placed a different
tongue in their mouth".

2. **The Sargon Birth Legend** (Neo-Assyrian / Neo-Babylonian Akkadian; K 3401 + Sm 2118 and K 4470 from Nineveh, the
school extract BM 47449 from Babylon; K 7249 not available to us). Sargon of Akkad (c. 2334–2279 BCE) tells in the
first person how his mother, an *ēnetu* (high priestess?), conceived and bore him in secret, set him in a reed
basket sealed with bitumen and cast him on the river; Aqqi the water-drawer drew him out, raised him as his son and
made him a gardener; Ištar loved him and he became king; then the list of his deeds and a challenge to every later
king. Probably composed under Sargon II of Assyria (722–705 BCE), the namesake who claimed the old king's heritage.

## Two purposes (guidelines §1)

- **Bible comparison.** For Enmerkar: **Gen 11:1–9** (one language, the confusion of tongues, the bricks, the building
that reaches heaven, the scattering), Gen 10 (the tables of nations "by their tongues"; Erech/Uruk in Nimrod's
kingdom, 10:10), Zeph 3:9 (שָׂפָה בְרוּרָה), Isa 11:6–9 and 65:25 (the peace among the beasts), **Exod 4:10**
(כְּבַד פֶּה), the messengers and their formulas (Gen 32:4–6; Num 20:14–17; Judg 11:12–28; 2 Kgs 18–19), the
writing of the word (Exod 24:12; 32:15–16; Deut 27:8; Isa 8:1; Jer 36; Hab 2:2), the famine and the grain (Gen 41–
47), the rain from the god (Deut 11:10–17), the contest of kings by riddles (1 Kgs 10:1–13; Judg 14). For Sargon:
**Exod 2:1–10** (the Levite mother, the hidden child, the papyrus box daubed with bitumen and pitch, the river, the
child drawn out, adopted as a son and named), Exod 1:22 (the river), 2:16–19 (Moses drawing water), the exposed or
hidden child (Gen 21:15–19; 2 Kgs 11:2–3), Gen 10:8–12 (Nimrod and Akkad), Isa 20:1 (Sargon II), the boasts of kings
(Isa 10:8–14; 37:24–25) and the challenge to successors (Deut 17:14–20 inverted).

- **The soul of the ancients**, equal in standing. Kingship and its legitimation (the king chosen in the goddess's
  heart; the king as son of the sun-god; a usurper who tells his own humble birth); rivalry and prestige between a
  river-plain city without stone or metal and a mountain city full of them (the economy of luxury goods; diplomacy by
  messenger and riddle); how they imagined the origin of writing (because a mouth grew tired) and of the many
  languages (a god's act; a golden age, or a hope?); the gods' household (Inana between two lords; Enki's wisdom;
  Nisaba's house of wisdom; Iškur's storm); the messenger's craft (memorizing word for word); the school that copied
  and loved these texts; a king's autobiography as a literary form (*narû*); the foundling, the gardener and the
  goddess's love.

## The projects

| # | Project folder | Text | Base text | Lines | Files |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | `1-אנמרכר-ואדון-ארטה/` | Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta | ETCSL 1.8.2.3 (`../sources/ETCSL/1.8.2.3-...-.../`); ORACC Q000369 lemma + morph; Mittermayer 2009 (open access) | 641 (1–636 with 11A, 106A, 185A, 185B, 365B and the alternative lines A–D of one manuscript for 400–403; ETCSL has no 369, 608–610) | `annotated-1.rtl.md` (1–155), `annotated-2.rtl.md` (156–307), `annotated-3.rtl.md` (308–469), `annotated-4.rtl.md` (470–636) |
| 2 | `2--אגדת-הולדת-סרגון/` | The Sargon Birth Legend | King 1907 vol. II pp. 87–96, transcribed from the page images (`../sources/King-1907--.../`); eBL catalogue | 49 (King's col. I 1–32, col. II 1–17) | `annotated.rtl.md` |
| 4 | `4-אגדת-כותה/` | The Cuthaean Legend of Narām-Sîn (Round 5, run 5, 2026-10-31) | eBL L/1/12 (`../sources/eBL/Cuthaean-*/`): five chapters – OB I, OB II, MB A, MB B (Ḫattuša), SB; ed. Mitto et al., tr. Foster | 345 (`SB.80`, `OBI.b+12`, `MBA.c+3`) | `annotated-OBI.rtl.md`, `-OBII`, `-MBA`, `-MBB`, `-SB` |
| 3 | `3--אגדת-אתנה/` | Etana (Round 3, run 2, 2026-10-22) | eBL L/1/9 (`../sources/eBL/Etana-*/`): six chapters – OB Morgan, OB Susa, MA Aššur, SB I–III; ed. Földi et al., tr. Foster | 585 (eBL labels with the chapter key: `OBM.7`, `MA.c+3`, `II.142`) | `annotated-OBM.rtl.md`, `-OBS`, `-MA`, `-I`, `-II`, `-III` (one per eBL chapter) |

Rank 3: ETCSL's English and Mittermayer 2009's German (EA); King 1907's English and the few lines of Westenholz 1997
quoted on the web (SB); Foster's English in eBL (ET). Not available: Cohen 1973, Vanstiphout 2003, Westenholz 1997, Lewis 1980 (records: `../sources/_records-only--Legends-of-kings/`).

**Reading order for the commentary:** EA 1–64 (Uruk and Aratta; the plea) → 65–155 (Inana's answer; the command; the
spell of Nudimmud) → 156–307 (the first exchange) → 308–455 (the grain and the sceptre) → 456–556 (the champion, the
heavy mouth and the first letter; the storm) → 557–636 (the end) → SB I 1–12 (the birth, the basket, the river, Aqqi,
Ištar) → SB I 13–32, II (the deeds, the challenge, the beasts) → **Etana** (each version on its own, in the
order of time; for the story: OBM 1–14 / SB I – kingship from heaven → SB II 1–72 / OBS / MA a–c – the eagle and the
serpent → SB II 73–152 / OBM b–c / MA d–f – the pit, the prayer for a son, the rescue → SB III / MA g–i – the dreams and
the flights).

## Shared conventions

- **`renderings.md` binds both projects**; it inherits the temple, lament and creation corpora's Sumerian renderings
  and the flood and law corpora's Akkadian ones (§0 there), and the rule "a Sumerian word takes the Hebrew of its
  Akkadian equivalent" — which here makes the two texts meet (Sum. *bal* "cross" and Akk. *nabalkutu* = חָצָה;
  *kur₂* and *nakāru* = שְׁנָה; *eme* and *lišānu* = לָשׁוֹן).
- **Repeated lines get identical Hebrew** (command → delivery, the journey, the messenger's greeting, "say to him"):
  `kings_tools.py pars EA FROM TO` lists each line's earlier copies with their Hebrew; `verify` checks the fixed
  formulas and lists identical transliterations with different Hebrew.
- **The annotated file is the only source of the Hebrew**: `kings_tools.py build KEY` generates `translation.rtl.md`.
- **Parallels index:** per file in `project.md` (`### Parallels index (<KEY>)`, KEY = EA1 … EA4, SB; columns exactly
  `| Line | Source | Hebrew rendering | Bible | Tag | Comment |`), merged into `parallels-index.md` by `build_parallels_index.py` (Genesis first, then Exodus).

- **How this run was done (2026-10-21):** the cloud session had no sub-agent tool, so the coordinator worked through
  the translator chain itself, strictly in order (EA1 → EA2 → EA3 → EA4, then SB), each part drafted from its data file
  with the earlier parts' Hebrew in front of it, the proposals merged into `renderings.md` §9 after each part, and the
  three review passes done per part.

**Etana (project 3, added 2026-10-22, Round 3 run 2):** the childless king of Kiš, the eagle and the serpent, and the
ascent to heaven for the "plant of birth"; for Gen 11:4 (ascent and "name", without a tower), Gen 30:1, 14–23 (the
plea and the "disgrace"), Gen 37 (the pit), Gen 28:12–17 and 37–41 (dreams), Isa 14:12–15, Obad 1:4, Exod 19:4,
Deut 32:11, Ezek 17 (the eagle). Its renderings: `renderings.md` §10 (fixed before drafting; §10.6 what each part
fixed). It was translated by four sub-agent translators in sequence (ET2 → ET1 → ET3 → ET4; the coordinator merged
and pushed after each), one part at a time (quotas: guidelines §5.1).

## Tools (in this folder)

| Script | What |
|---|---|
| `kings_tools.py verify KEY [--strict]` | Entries against the base line list, transliteration = base text, one `>` per entry, reserved and gated strings (renderings §5), name traps (lines and headings), fixed formulas, translation = `>` lines, identical lines with different Hebrew. |
| `kings_tools.py build KEY` | The clean translation, verified. |
| `kings_tools.py grep KEY\|all '<regex>'`; `lines KEY FROM-TO`; `pars KEY FROM TO` | How a Hebrew string was used so far (all = + the lament, temple and creation corpora's Sumerian texts); the base lines; the earlier copies of a repeated line with their Hebrew. |
| `kings_tools.py conc EA [out]`; `data EA FROM TO out` | ETCSL ↔ ORACC concordance; a translator's line data (ETCSL, ORACC lemma + morph, ETCSL and Mittermayer at the line). |
| `kings_tools.py data ET FROM TO out`; `pars ET FROM TO` | Etana: a translator's line data (the eBL block of each line + its related lines in all six versions with the Hebrew already given); the related lines of a range. `verify ET` licenses the reserved words by the eBL lemma (RESERVED_ET); `build ET` prints the eBL label under each version's heading. |
| `build_parallels_index.py` | `parallels-index.md` from the per-file tables. |

## Status

| # | Project | Status |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | Enmerkar and the Lord of Aratta | **complete** (2026-10-21): 641 entries in four parts, three review passes each; `translation.rtl.md` built; open decisions in `project.md` (EA1–EA4) |
| 4 | The Cuthaean Legend | **complete (first draft)** (2026-10-31): 345 entries in four parts (CL1 SB 1–93, CL2 SB 94–180, CL3 MB A–B, CL4 OB I–II), one translator resumed part by part, three passes each; `verify CL --strict` OK; `translation.rtl.md` built; renderings §11; brief `translator-brief--cuthaean.md` |
| 3 | Etana | **complete** (2026-10-22): 585 entries in four parts (ET1–ET4), three review passes each; `translation.rtl.md` built; open decisions in `project.md` |
| 2 | The Sargon Birth Legend | **complete on King 1907** (2026-10-21): 49 entries, three review passes; `translation.rtl.md` built; **to be checked against Westenholz 1997 and K 7249** (not reachable) |

Print stubs: `../אנמרכר-ואדון-ארטה/1-מלכים-אגדות-הדפסה.rtl.md`, `../הולדת-אגדת-2-מלכים-אגדות-הדפסה.rtl.md`, `../אתנה-אגדת-3-מלכים-אגדות-הדפסה.rtl.md`. Hand-off: `handoff--round2-run6.md`.